

THE MUSTER

The King's Crusade — Module One

OVERVIEW

The party is summoned to Duncarrow, seat of Xavier III of Harrowmark, and chosen personally for the crusade he has called. Before the muster can march, Harrowmark asks one more thing of them: help see off a wyvern that has turned on the hold of Greywatch. The session ends with the coalition's ships or column setting out, and the table making the campaign's first real choice — the sea road or the mountain road. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content is built to fill out the rest of a five-hour session, not to be squeezed into it, and can be skipped entirely on a slow night without costing the module anything it needs later.

If the party does not already know one another, run Scene 1 as their introduction rather than as exposition — they can meet on the road, all answering the same rider. If they do already know each other, skip straight to the summons and let the scene move.

THE WEIGHT OF HARROWMARK

Play the texture of the place before anything else happens in it. Harrowmark in the last cold weeks before winter is grey stone under a greyer sky, woodsmoke that never quite clears

the low valleys, and light that arrives late and leaves early. Nothing glows, nothing hums, nothing remembers a kindness done to it — water is only water here, and a mile is exactly as long as it looks. That flatness is not absence; it is a fact about the place, stated plainly, and it is what will make Elduvaine's magic land as wonder rather than as a rules explanation when the party finally crosses into it.

What Harrowmark has instead is competence. Doors are barred against weather, not spirits. Watch fires burn all night on every hold's high ground, not from superstition but because something with wings sometimes comes out of the crags, and has for longer than anyone can date. People here do not gasp at danger; they reach for the nearest rope, or pike, or child, in that order, and get on with it. Voice every NPC in this module — Xavier included — from that same flat, competent register, and save the wonder for later.

Fill the place out as you go. Duncarrow's yard is humans and dwarves and orcs and a scatter of everyone else, all of them Harrowmark-born and none of them remarkable to each other: an orc farrier arguing with a dwarf quartermaster about the same sixteen horseshoes for the third day running, a half-elf sergeant reading a duty roster aloud to a queue that is not listening. Nobody in this module comments on any of it, and neither should the narration. The party comes from here. This is simply what home looks like.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Summons	20 min	Optional introductions fold in here if needed.
2. Audience with the King	45–60 min	The Promise, the crusade, and the party's place in it.
3. The Wyvern at Greywatch	90–120 min	The session's combat. See DC table and stat block below.
4. The Muster's End	30–45 min	Departure, and the road choice — Branch Ledger entry 1.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Nothing in this module is a trick. The wyvern at Greywatch is exactly what Brenna Vane says it is: a young, hungry animal pushed out of its usual range by a harder winter than most, doing what wyverns do. It has no connection to Vale, to Elduvaine, or to anything the party will learn about later. Its only job is to be the first thing this campaign asks the party to be brave about, and to show them — and the table — what "unimpressed" actually looks like from the inside.

DM Only: Xavier is not yet the Wyvernheart, and nothing in this module may suggest that he will be. He does not fly, does not fight the wyvern personally if he is present at Greywatch (he should not be — keep him at Duncarrow), and

no NPC may use the name early, even as a joke or a slip. The name has to be earned on the page, in front of the players, or it is only a title he turned up already wearing.

SCENE 1: THE SUMMONS

Wherever the party is when this begins, make it somewhere ordinary — a roadside inn, a garrison bunkhouse, a farmhold at the edge of the crags. The rider is easy to hear before he is seen: hooves on frozen ruts, faster than anyone rides without a reason, and by the time he is in view his horse is lathered white at the neck despite the cold.

The rider comes at a hard trot, mud and ice to the knee of his horse, and does not slow at the gate. "Duncarrow," he says, to whoever is closest, breath fogging between words. "The king summons you by name. Today, if you can manage it." He says each name once, plainly, the way a man reads a list he has already checked twice, and does not wait to be thanked before he turns his horse back the way he came.

Play this scene short. Its only job is to get the party moving toward Duncarrow with a name attached to the summons — their own. If the party has not met, this is where they cross paths: on the same road, answering the same rider, sizing each other up over the two or three days' ride it takes to reach the seat, trading the little each of them knows about why a king would want them by name. Nobody in Harrowmark is summoned by name for a small reason, and the party should arrive at Duncarrow already half-certain of that, before anyone tells them so.

SCENE 2: AUDIENCE WITH THE KING

Duncarrow is a working fortress, not a palace — grey stone, low ceilings, arrow-slit windows that let in more cold than light. The great hall smells of woodsmoke, wet dog, and oiled steel rather than incense; the tapestries on its walls are march-maps and hide charts, not heraldry. Guards at the door look tired rather than ceremonial, and nod the party through without announcing them — Duncarrow has had a great many visitors this season, and does not have the staff to make an occasion of one more.

Xavier receives the party standing, at a steward's table crowded with maps and weighted at the corners with what look like ordinary stones. He is not what the songs will eventually make of him: greying at the temples earlier than he should be, a soldier's build going a little soft from a year of councils rather than campaigns, dressed plainly enough that a stranger might take him for one of his own captains. Only when he looks up does the room organize itself around him — not because anyone commands it to, but because everyone in it has clearly done this before.

He does not make them kneel. "I know your names," he says, before anyone has given one, and it is not a boast — he simply has. "A kingdom I have never seen has been taken by a man I have never met, and I am asking you to help me take it back. I will not pretend that is a small thing to ask of anyone.

Let Xavier speak plainly about the Promise — a share in Elduvaine's resident magic, and the run of the Ysolde Archive, for those who answer the call — without dwelling on it; the sourcebook covers its substance, and this scene's job is the man, not the policy. He is direct, economical, uncomfortable with the theatre of being knelt to, and visibly more at ease discussing march order and supply than titles. If a player asks him something personal, he answers once, briefly, and changes the subject; he did not survive his own youth by talking about it.

DM Only: if a player pushes on why he chose them specifically, he has a real answer, not a flattering one: he asked his officers for the people other people trusted under pressure, not the people other people were impressed by. He believes this is the same thing Harrowmark has always valued in its own wyvern-hunters, and it is not a coincidence that Greywatch is where he is about to send them next.

He closes the audience by asking one thing of them before the muster marches: Greywatch, three days out, has sent word that a wyvern has taken to raiding its herds and, twice now, its people. He would rather send the crusade's own chosen than levy more of Greywatch's own dead.

He does not walk them out. A steward does that, through a yard full of the ordinary business of a fortress readying for war — barrels counted, horses shod, a smith's hammer going somewhere out of sight — and the party's last sight of Xavier, glanced back through the hall door, is of a man already bent over his maps again before they have finished crossing the threshold.

SCENE 3: THE WYVERN AT GREYWATCH

Greywatch announces itself before the road does: watchtowers on every high point, each with a horn-bearer standing a longer shift than seems reasonable, and a palisade studded here and there with a wyvern claw or a length of jaw nailed up as a ward that everyone insists is decoration and no one will take down. It is a hold built for exactly this, by people who have buried others to wyverns before and, without much ceremony about it, expect to again. Greywatch is roughly half dwarves and half orcs with everyone else filling the gaps, and its wyvern-watch has been organised the same way for nine centuries: dwarves on the pikes, because a dwarf braced properly does not move, and orcs on the ropes, because somebody has to be strongest at the end of a line with a wyvern on the other end of it. Nobody here regards this as worth explaining, and will be visibly impatient with an outsider who asks. Huntmaster Brenna Vane meets the party at the gate, sizes them up without much comment, and puts them to work.

"It took two lambs and a shepherd's boy's arm Tuesday last," Brenna says, already walking, not waiting to see if they follow. "Young, hungry, pushed down off the high crags by the cold — not clever, not old enough to be clever. We'll rope it if we can and put it back where it came from. We'll kill it if we have to. Either way, nobody's grandmother is losing a leg on my watch. You keep up or you keep out of the way."

Give the party the rest of the daylight to see Greywatch properly before dusk brings the fight: pens reinforced with iron banding rather than wood, a bone yard behind the smithy where old kills are rendered down for nothing gets wasted here, children who know the horn-calls — one long for sighted, three short for struck, one long again for down — the way other children know a nursery rhyme. Nobody here is grim about it. This is simply what a season looks like.

RUNNING THE ENCOUNTER

The wyvern comes at dusk, out of a sky gone the color of a bruise, and is heard before it is seen — a dry, heavy beat of wings, then a cry that every dog in the hold answers at once. It strikes from height, going first for whatever looks least defended: a penned animal, a straggler, a party member who has wandered from the group. Brenna and two or three Greywatch hunters (use commoner or scout-tier statistics as needed; they are support, not combatants, and should not be expected to survive a direct hit) fight alongside the party with ropes and long pikes rather than swords, calling positions to each other in the flat, practiced shorthand of people who have done this before — an orc roper with a line already spinning before the thing is in range, two dwarves setting a pike-brace into the frozen ground and swearing at it in the tone of people who do this every winter.

Harrowmark does not fight wyverns the way most parties expect to fight a dragon. A PC adjacent to the wyvern, or within its reach, may spend their action fixing a hunting rope to a wing or leg (Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Sleight of Hand), DC 13 — Brenna will call out which, and why, the first time it comes up). Three successful ropes from three different characters ground the wyvern: it loses its fly speed until it breaks free (its action, a DC 13 Athletics contest against the ropes) or the encounter ends. A grounded wyvern fighting on the ground, hemmed in by pikes, is a substantially safer fight than one still in the air, and this is deliberate — it is the module's built-in partial resolution, not a trick or a trap. Play the moment it goes down for everything it is worth: the ropes snapping taut, the hold-folk shouting the count, the sudden and enormous silence of something huge no longer in the air.

The stinger is the fight's real danger and should read as one — not a number on a sheet but a visible, spreading

wrongness in whoever it hits: the wound going numb, then cold, then someone else shouting for the antitoxin before the poison finishes its work. The wyvern is unaligned and not suicidal. If it drops to 25 hit points or fewer, or is grounded and clearly losing, it breaks off and flees at its next opportunity rather than fighting to the death. A fleeing wyvern that escapes counts as a full success at the table — Greywatch does not expect a corpse, only a hold that is safe again.

SCALING THE FIGHT

The wyvern below is the SRD statistics unmodified, run against Dungeon Master's Guide adjusted-XP thresholds for 5th-level characters (Easy 250 / Medium 500 / Hard 750 / Deadly 1100 per character). A single monster carries a $\times 1$ multiplier at party sizes of 3–5 and $\times 0.5$ at 6 or more — the party-of-six discount that quietly softens most encounters for large tables, and it lands hard here.

Party size	Adjusted XP	Deadly threshold	Reads as	Compensate with
4	2,300	4,400	Medium–Hard	Run as written.
5	2,300	5,500	just under Medium	Run as written; the rope tactic and morale give it teeth the raw math understates.
6	1,150	6,600	below Easy	Do not add a second wyvern — crossing the 1→2 monster boundary roughly doubles the multiplier and overcorrects badly. Instead add one complication: a burning hayrick blocking the herd pens, or a trapped child in the loft, that raises the practical stakes without touching the monster count.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Notice the summons rider is telling the truth about Duncarrow	Insight	10	Easy
Read that Xavier is uncomfortable with pageantry, not with them	Insight	13	Moderate
Track the wyvern's likely strike point before dusk	Survival	13	Moderate
Fix a hunting rope to the wyvern (per attempt; three needed)	Athletics / Sleight of Hand	13	Moderate
Steady panicking livestock or hold-folk mid-attack	Animal Handling / Persuasion	13	Moderate

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Spot the stinger wind-up in time to call a warning	Perception	16	Hard
Earn Brenna's open respect rather than her polite tolerance	Persuasion (or demonstrated competence)	16	Hard

STAT BLOCK

Wyvern

Large dragon, unaligned

Armor Class: 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 110 (13d10 + 39)

Speed: 20 ft., fly 80 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
19 (+4)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	5 (-3)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Skills: Perception +4

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages: —

Challenge: 6 (2,300 XP)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The wyvern makes two attacks: one with its bite and one with its stinger. While flying, it can use its claws in place of one other attack.

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. Hit: 11 (2d6 + 4) piercing damage.

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (2d8 + 4) slashing damage.

Stinger. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. Hit: 11 (2d6 + 4) piercing damage. The target must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw, taking 24 (7d6) poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

SCENE 4: THE MUSTER'S END

Whatever became of the wyvern, the party returns to Duncarrow to find the muster nearly ready to move. The yard that was ordinary business three days ago is now a camp too large for it — wagons loaded and lashed, Harrowmark levies falling into column by the sound of a horn rather than a shouted order, and, past the edge of the Harrowmark tents, the first coalition banners: colors and cuts of armor the party has not seen before, voices in accents that mark out where in the muster Oksitan and Auberitz have pitched their own camps. Nobody introduces the party to any of it yet — that is a later module's work — but it should be visibly, unmistakably there, the first sign that this war is bigger than Harrowmark.

Xavier meets them once more, briefly, in the noise of it rather than the quiet of his hall, to say the thing he did not say at the audience.

"Greywatch will remember this longer than I will be able to thank you for it," he says, close enough to be heard over the camp without raising his voice. "That is worth more than anything I can pin to your coats. But I mean to pin something anyway."

This is where the road is chosen — sea or mountain. Let the party decide it in character, weighing whatever they have heard in camp (speed and a side-conquest against the sea, or a longer and harder overland march against the mountains); do not let Xavier decide it for them. Whichever they choose, hand off directly to that module.

NPC PROFILES

XAVIER III OF HARROWMARK

Speech: short sentences, plain words, and a habit of answering the question actually asked rather than the one people expect. Never raises his voice; the room quiets for him anyway.

Open thread: he has told no one in this party, and will tell no one for some time, that leaving Harrowmark under a regency he does not fully trust is the decision from this crusade that frightens him most — not Vale, not the road, that. A DM looking for a private, human moment with him later in the campaign has this to draw on.

HUNTMASTER BRENNA VANE

A dwarf in her second century, Greywatch's huntmaster for sixty years of it, missing two fingers on her left hand to a stinger she still calls "a fair trade." Runs Greywatch's wyvern-watch and, unofficially, a hold-wide betting ledger on every kill — which limb, which method, how long. **Speech:** dry, economical, allergic to being thanked directly; deflects gratitude by immediately assigning a chore.

Open thread: if the party impresses her, she offers what Greywatch actually has to give — not gold, but competence: a standing invitation to send word if Harrowmark-trained hands are ever needed again, which a DM can call in during Module 8 or later as a recurring, grounded ally rather than a one-scene NPC.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE BETTING LEDGER

Before or after the wyvern, Brenna's ledger makes the rounds of Greywatch's hall — a battered book of wagers going back decades, with a fresh page opened the moment the party arrives. Play this for pure levity: hold-folk arguing odds, someone trying to get the party to wager on themselves, an old wound reopened as an anecdote rather than a warning. No mechanical stakes; this is a relief valve, planned for rather than hoped for.

FORTIFYING GREYWATCH

If the table wants a prep phase before the wyvern strikes, run a short group effort to reinforce the hold's pens and towers — two or three successful checks (Athletics, Investigation, or anything else a player can justify) buy the party an advantageous position for the fight: advantage on the first round's initiative, or the wyvern's opening attack targeting a decoy instead of a person. Skip this cleanly if the table is eager to get to the fight itself.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **The wyvern's fate.** Killed, driven off, or (rarely) roped and released elsewhere — track which. Greywatch remembers a killing as competence and a driving-off as mercy; both earn Brenna's respect, and only a table that badly mishandles the fight (fleeing, refusing to help, or getting a Greywatch hunter killed through carelessness) should lose it.
- **The road choice — Branch Ledger entry 1.** Sea road or mountain road, decided here and carried into Module 2A or 2B. This is the campaign's first tracked divergence; record it in the DM Reference Guide the moment it is made, including who argued for which and why, since that reasoning is worth revisiting when the drowned king's aftermath reaches the party in Module 5.

LOOT

- **A Greywatch hunting pike.** Masterwork but not magical — a reach weapon balanced by people who use them for a living. Re flavor as a longspear or glaive per the wielder's preference; treat as a normal weapon of its type, finely made.
- **A vial of Greywatch antitoxin.** A single-use draught brewed from the hold's long experience with stinger wounds. Grants advantage on the next saving throw against poison damage or the poisoned condition within the next 24 hours.
- **Two potions of healing.** Pressed on the party by Greywatch's healer with the flat instruction to bring them back empty rather than unused. Standard SRD potions of healing (2d4 + 2).
- **A blade out of Duncarrow's armory.** A +1 weapon of the recipient's type, cut with a dwarven runesmith's marks along the spine — worked magic, carried in the steel, exactly the kind Harrowmark makes and the only kind it has. Xavier hands it over without ceremony and slightly too fast, in the manner of a man who has decided not to make a speech about it.

- **Xavier's token.** A plain iron badge, the king's own mark, given without ceremony. It carries no mechanical benefit and opens no doors by itself — but it is recognizable to anyone who has served under Xavier, and a DM may let it matter socially wherever that is true.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*